

Session 26: Ezekiel's Temple Tour

Key Takeaways

- The glory of Yahweh that left the temple in chapter 10 returns to this new temple in chapter 43.
- The city is decentralized and the priesthood is renewed. All of the details of the organization of the temple, the priesthood, and the land reverse Israel’s abuses and purify the people and the land.
- The number 25, featured prominently in the temple dimensions, evokes a mid-point in the 50-year Jubilee cycle.

Ezekiel's Temple Vision

Ezekiel portrays the future of the covenant people through the imagery and vocabulary of a priestly imagination, sketching the contours of the restored temple and land, with Yahweh returning to the temple (43:1-7) after his abandonment of it in chapter 11.

Macro Design of Ezekiel 40-48



Ezekiel 40-48. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ezekiel (2021).

Structure and Themes of Ezekiel's Temple Vision

The three main sections of the vision correspond to three broad themes.

1. 40:1-43:27: Yahweh returns to a purified temple to dwell among his people.
2. 44:1-46:24: A purified priesthood and its liturgy are restored to worship Yahweh with covenant fidelity.
3. 47:1-48:35: Israel is restored to a reorganized and holy territory, which then becomes the hub of a renewed creation.

The Macro Design of Ezekiel 40:1-43:27

Ezekiel 40:1-47

Visionary guidance from the east gate to the holy of holies

40:1-4

Introduction: Date and beginning of Ezekiel's vision

40:5-40:37

40:5-27

The outer gates of the temple complex

- **40:5-16** Entry into the outer east gate and its measurements
- **40:17-23** Movement to the outer north gate and its measurements
- **40:24-27** Movement to the outer south gate and its measurements

40:28-37

The inner gates of the temple complex

- **40:28-31** Movement to the inner south gate and its measurements
- **40:32-34** Movement to the inner east gate and its measurements
- **40:35-37** Movement to the inner north gate and its measurements

40:38-47

The inner court's room and tables for sacrifices

- **40:38** The room for washing sacrificial animals
- **40:39-43** The eight sacrificial tables: location and measurements
- **40:44-47** **The inner rooms for priests: the Zadokites who come near to Yahweh at altar**

Ezekiel 40:48-42:14

Description of the temple, its decorations, and the buildings around the temple

40:48-41:4

Entry into the temple and its measurements

- **40:48-49** Movement to the temple entry room and its measurements
- **41:1-2** Movement to the temple's main hall and its measurements
- **41:3-4** Movement to the temple's inner room and its measurements: holy of holies

41:5-15a

Description and measurement of the annexes of the temple and its surroundings

- **41:5-7** The temple's side-annexes and measurements
- **41:8-11** The temple and annex walls and inner court space around them
- **41:12-15a** The temple building and rear building's measurements

41:15b-26

Wall decorations and interior furnishing of the temple

- **41:15b-20** Decoration of the temple's main hall: wood, carved palms and cherubim
- **41:21-22** Decoration of the altar table of the temple's main hall
- **41:23-26** Decoration of the most holy and holy place doors: palms and cherubim

42:1-14

The rooms for the priests

- **42:1-10a** Description of the NW outer court rooms for the priests
- **42:10b-12** Description of the SW outer court rooms for the priests
- **42:13-14** Rooms for the priests who come near to Yahweh and serve

Ezekiel 42:15-43:27

Conclusion of temple measurements, Yahweh enters the temple and the altar is inaugurated

42:15-20

Conclusion of measuring the temple

- **42:15** "Finishing" (כלה) of measurements, exit through the east gate
- **42:16-19** The four sides of the temple complex are measured
- **42:20** Total measurements of the temple complex

43:1-12

Yahweh enters the temple

- **43:1-4** Visions of the Glory of Yahweh entering the temple through east gates
- **43:5-9** Ezekiel taken into inner court, Speech 1: This temple is free of Israel's past defilements
- **43:10-11** Ezekiel in inner court, Speech 2: Ezekiel to report the proportion of the divine temple

43:13-27

Inauguration of the central altar

- **43:13-17** Description and measurements of the central altar
- **43:18-27** Seven day inauguration of the central altar—Zadokite priests come near and serve seven days to "finish" (כלה) the inauguration

Ezekiel 40:1-43:27. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ezekiel (2021).

The New Temple and Yahweh's Return

The purpose of Ezekiel's visionary tour is easy to miss. Why is Ezekiel shown the Heaven-on-Earth temple, the ideal sanctuary? The opening and closing paragraphs of the tour (in [Ezek. 40:1-4](#) and [Ezek. 43:10-12](#)) create a frame around this first part of Ezekiel 40-48, and they make very clear why God has taken Ezekiel on this dream tour. He is to declare to Israel what he has seen ([Ezek. 40:4](#), [43:10](#)) as a form of prophetic rebuke ([Ezek. 43:11](#)) mixed with hope so that Israel will see just how badly they distorted the purpose of the temple ([Ezek. 43:7-9](#)) in comparison to its heavenly divine ideal ([Ezek. 43:10-11](#)).

Translation and Literary Design of Ezekiel 40:1-4

- a 1 **In the twenty-fifth year** **of our exile** ,
b at the beginning of the year,
b' on the tenth of the month,
a' **in the fourteenth year** **after the city was struck** ,

on that very day,
the hand of Yahweh was upon me,
and he brought me to there .

2 In visions of Elohim **he brought me** into **the land of Israel** ,
and he set me on **a very high mountain** ,
and on it to the south there was **a structure like a city** ,

3 **and he brought me there** ,
and look, a **man** whose **appearance** was like the **appearance** of bronze,
with a linen cord in his hand, and a measuring rod;
and he was standing in the gate,

4 and the **man** said to me,
"Son of a human,
see with your **eyes** ,
hear with your ears,
and set your heart to all that I am going to make you **see** ,
for you have been brought here in order for you to **see** it,
declare (הגיד) to the house of Israel all that you **see** ."

Ezekiel 40:1-4. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ezekiel (2021).

The 25th Year of Exile

Ezekiel dates this vision 20 years after the vision by the river Khebar ("in the fifth year of king Jehoiachin's exile," [1:2](#)), and 14 years after the destruction of Jerusalem in 586 B.C.E., so this places the vision in the year

The Beginning of the Year

The reference to the beginning of the year could refer to either the first month of the agricultural year (Nisan, in the Spring, March/April), or also to the first month of the liturgical calendar, which was the seventh month of the agricultural calendar, (Tishri, in the fall, September/October; see [Lev. 23:27](#)).

If it was Nisan, then this was precisely the month and day that Babylonians performed the *akitu* festival in which Marduk's statue would be ushered from outside the city into the temple complex where he was enthroned over the new year.

If it was Tishri, then the 10th day was the Day of Atonement, the day on which, every 50 years, the Jubilee was announced (see [Lev. 23:26-32](#) and [25:8-12](#)).

It's entirely possible that the month is left unspecified so that the same date would evoke both associations. The connection to the 50th Jubilee year seems undeniable, and note that "in the 25th year" would mark exactly half of a Jubilee cycle. This is precisely the numerical logic at work in Daniel's "a time, two times, and half a time" (= 3 1/2, see [Dan. 7:25](#) and [12:7](#)).

Also, if this vision is 20 years after the first vision which took place when Ezekiel turned 30 years old, that means that this date also marks Ezekiel's 50th birth year, exactly the year that he would have stepped down from his priestly duties (see [Num. 4:3](#) and [8:23-25](#)).

Twenty-Five

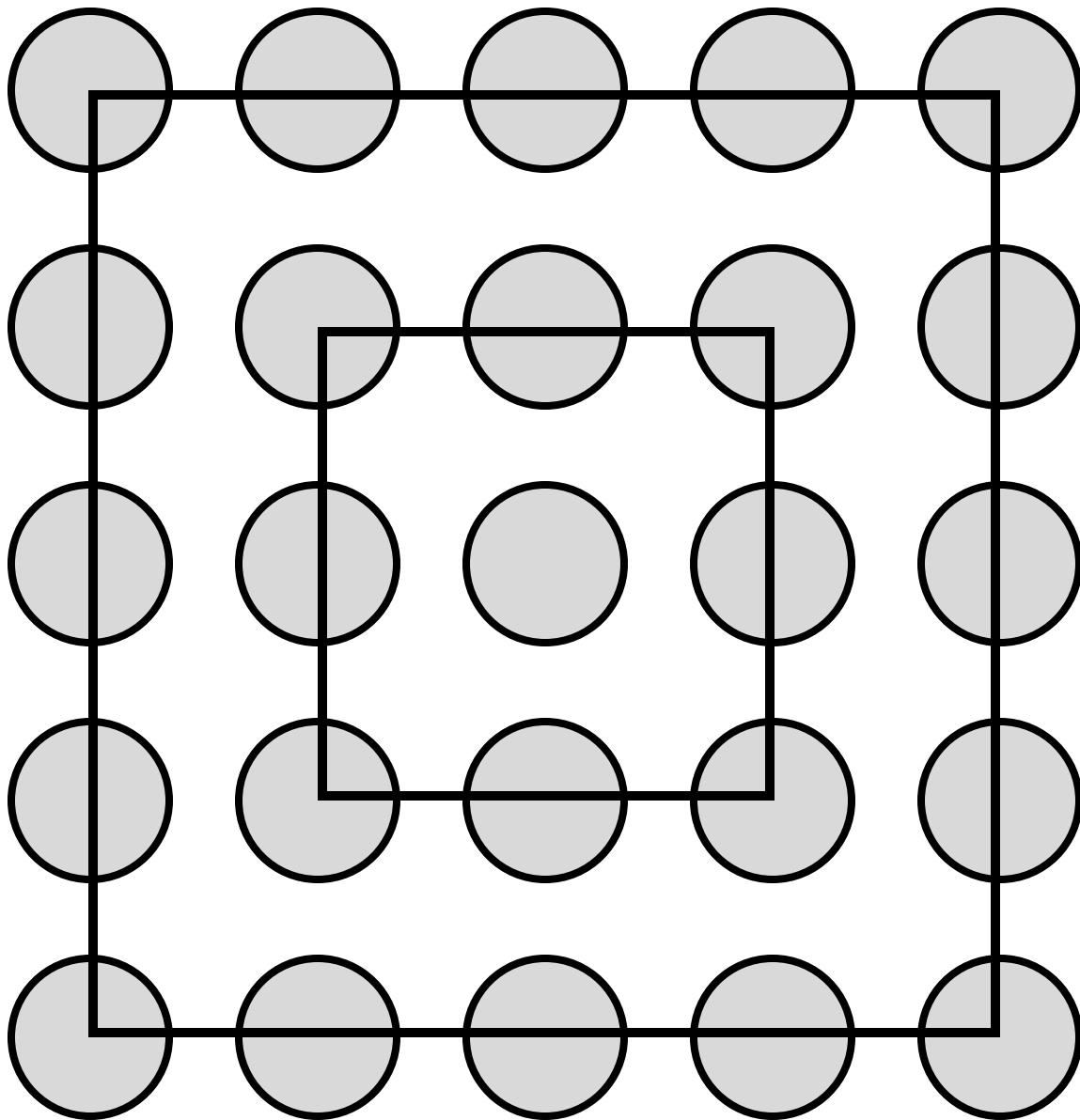
Twenty-five is a highly significant number in Ezekiel's vision [the following is a summary of Stephen Cook, [Ezekiel 38-48](#), p. 129-130 and John Bergsma, "The Restored Temple as 'Built Jubilee' in Ezekiel 40-48"].

Consider all the multiples of 25 in his temple tour.

- The vision happens in the 25th year of the exile ([40:1](#)).
- The entry gate houses are 25 cubits wide (see [40:13, 21, 25](#)) and 2 x 25 cubits long (= 50, see [40:15, 21, 25](#)).
- The distance between the outer and inner gate houses is 4 x 25 cubits (= 100, see [40:19, 23, 27](#)).
- The temple compound as a whole is 20 x 25 cubits, that is, 500 cubits square.
- The total number of steps by which one ascends 100 square cubit inner court comes to 25 ([40:26, 31, 49](#) in the Septuagint).
- The facade of the outer court outside the north gate is 4 x 25 cubits (= 100, see [42:1](#)) long, and 2 x 25 cubits wide (= 50, see [42:2](#)).
- The outer wall of the outer court runs 2 x 25 cubits long (= 100, see [42:7](#)), and is filled with chamber rooms that are 2 x 50 cubits deep (= 50, see [42:8](#)).
- The entire central "reserved land" is 25 x 1000 (= 25,000 square cubits, [48:20](#)).
- The outer wall surrounding the temple complex is 500 cubits squared (= 50 x 10, see [42:16-20](#)), repeated four times. This last figure is significant, as the number 50 was the Jubilee number (7 x 7 + 1). The significance of a "ten-fold Jubilee" is operative in the visions of Daniel, where the "seven sevens of years are determined for your people" ([Dan. 9:25-27](#)).

The number 25 is packed with dense biblical symbolism.

- The 25th year is half of a Jubilee cycle, which happened every 7 x 7 years as a “super Sabbath” for all the people and land to be liberated unto freedom and rest.
- The number 25 is a square number (5 x 5), and it's also important that the numbers 3 and 4 stand behind the number: $25 = 3^2 + 4^2$. The numbers 3 and 4 loom large in Ezekiel's vision: three outer gates, three inner gates, four sides to the reserved portion, the temple precinct, and the city, four Levitical kitchens in the corners, the four horns of the altar.
- The number 25 is a centered square number: 25 is a number that can be laid out as dots on a plane to create a symmetrical pattern of concentric circles. This corresponds to the proportions of Ezekiel's temple complex. The central dot marks the location of the altar, while the inner court is proportioned to the inner circle marked by 3x3 dots (= 100 square cubits, see [40:47](#)), and the outer courtyard is proportioned to the outer circles of 5x5 dots (= 500 square cubits, see [45:2](#)). This creates a concentric pattern of nested zones arranged around a holy center, the altar.



Centered Square Number. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ezekiel (2021).

“What is the significance of this date for understanding the rest of the vision (chs. 40-48)? The deportees, in a sense 'half-way' through the exile, would be feeling the discouragement associated with 'mid-time,' and in need of a word of hope from the Lord. Ezekiel provides that in his vision. On the Day of Atonement—on which the old temple would have been cleansed and the Lord would have renewed his presence therein—Ezekiel foresees a new, cleansed temple to which the Lord’s presence returns ... By building the temple according to the jubilee number fifty, Ezekiel suggests that the temple in some sense is Israel’s jubilee; that is, it is in proper worship of the Lord that Israel experiences her true freedom The entire vision of restoration in chs. 40-48 [are] an eschatological proclamation of the jubilee on the Day of Atonement. The major themes of the vision all fit this paradigm: the concern for the restoration and purification of the temple evident throughout the vision corresponds to the purgation of the temple on the Day of Atonement. The vision’s extensive guidelines for the re-allocation of Israel’s land after the exile and the rules for

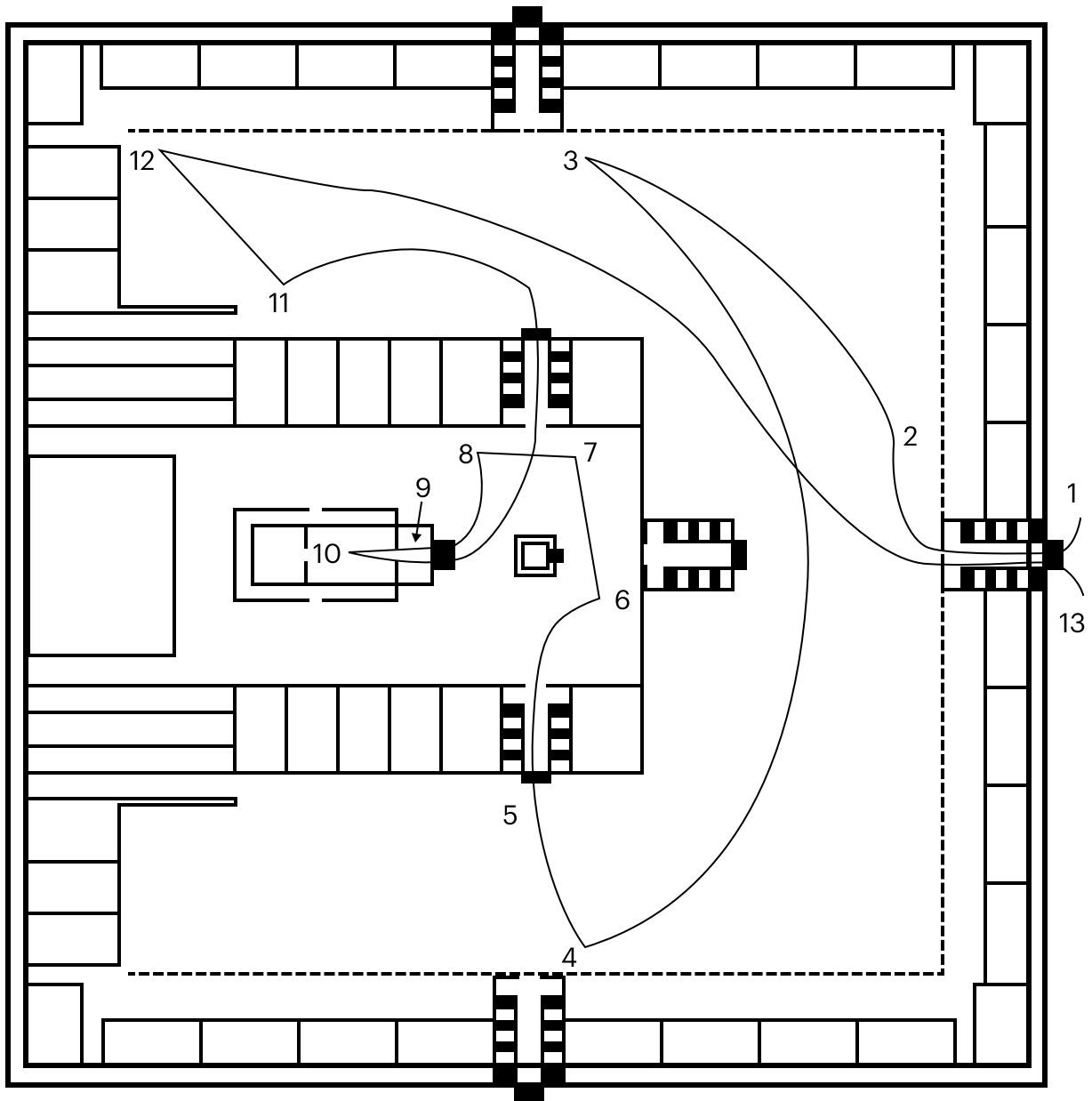
economic justice all correspond to the jubilee's concern to return Israelites to their ancestral land and re-establish economic equity."

Bergsma, John (2004). "The Restored Temple as 'Built Jubilee' in Ezekiel 40-48," *Proceedings of the Eastern Great Lakes and Midwestern Biblical Societies*, 24. 77-80.

"Some connection to the Jubilee seems undeniable. Having survived twenty-five years of exile on this very day, Ezekiel and his kinfolk were in a position to consider and even expect that they were at least halfway toward liberty from Babylonian activity and restoration to God's land ... On this highly symbolic Jubilee and New Year's date, at the point of Ezekiel's readiness for retirement, God's hand translates the prophet to a 'very high mountain' ... the archetypal cosmic mountain that connects heaven and birth."

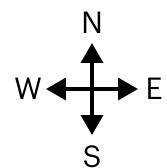
Cook, Stephen L. (2018). [*Ezekiel 38-48: A New Translation with Introduction and Commentary*](#). Yale University Press. 124-125.

From 40:5-42:20, Ezekiel is led on a virtual tour of the temple complex. He's led by a humanoid figure with measuring tools, and the horizontal dimensions of each area are mapped out. His tour takes him through the outer east gate, around the outer courtyard, then through the inner north gate, then into the temple itself, then back out and around the inner courtyard, then out through the inner south gate, back through the outer courtyard until he returns to where he started at the outer east gate.



Key

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|-------------|-------------|--------------|
| 1. 40:1-16 | 6. 40:32-34 | 10. 41:1-4 |
| 2. 40:17-19 | 7. 40:35-37 | 11. 42:1-14 |
| 3. 40:20-23 | 8. 40:44-46 | 12. 46:19-24 |
| 4. 40:24-27 | 9. 40:48-49 | 13. 42:15-20 |
| 5. 40:28-31 | | |



Ezekiel's Temple Layout. Block, Daniel (1998). [*The Book of Ezekiel, Chapters 25-48 \(The New International Commentary on the Old Testament\)*](#). Eerdmans.

Reflection Question

How is the number 25 related to the Jubilee cycle of Leviticus? What might it signify to the exiles of Ezekiel's time?